

Field Guides / Case studies

How a video business owner started moving off the project treadmill

Anonymised from a real member's coaching threads. No names or identifying details.

An owner who already ran her business by the numbers priced a one-off filming day for a new lead, then asked how the same work, with editing added, could be sold as a retainer. She built a real cost-of-delivery model, studied how a retainer business worked, and set out to test recurring done-for-you packages of her own.

What was the situation?

The situation was an owner who already treated the business like a business. She paid herself a salary and knew it didn't belong in net profit. She asked what share of revenue should go to marketing each year, and she was looking at how to put systems under her sales.

Then a lead came in from a media company that wanted her for filming only, no edit. She worked out a shooter day rate for the job, and pushed straight past it in the same breath: "if I want to make this for my business, with editing, as a retainer or one-off, how should I present it?"

The company that had sent the lead ran a social-media retainer model of its own. She studied it.

What was going wrong, and what did it cost?

What was going wrong was the shape of the income, not the quality of the work. A filming-only day rate is a one-off: it's quoted, delivered and finished, and nothing about it carries into the following month.

Nothing in her threads says the business was struggling. The cost was structural. Every one-off job ends on delivery, so the next month starts with the hunt again, and the only way to grow is to sell more days, which means more of the owner in every one of them. The company on the other side of that lead sold its work by the month. She decided to test a version of that model in her own area.

What did she change?

What she changed was the question she asked of her own work. The question stopped being "what's my rate for this job?" and became "what could a client buy from me every month?" She didn't invent a new service. She took what she already did, shooting and editing, and started shaping it into packages a client could buy on a recurring basis.

Then she built the price under it. Her cost-of-delivery model had four parts: her time (shooting, editing, travel and admin), her gear (maintenance and depreciation), her business expenses (insurance, software and marketing), and a profit margin on top. That's the pricing system most of the owners in the same set of threads were missing.

She also started testing a done-for-you, plug-and-play content package for small businesses without much budget, and worked on the messaging, the copy and the script to sell it.

The same instinct turned up in another member's thread, who proposed a "steady stream of content" system to a client so the client wouldn't have to think about video at all.

The step-by-step version of this move, with the retainer skeleton and the email to an existing client, is on the guide this story belongs to: [how to move from one-off video projects to recurring revenue](#).

What happened next?

What happened next was the work around the offer. After three years she admitted she'd never had a solid LinkedIn plan and got serious about one: profile, connection strategy, and the tools to run it. She also hired a VA for social media and weighed handing the LinkedIn outreach to her too, the first signs of passing the top of the funnel to someone else.

The threads record the decision, the cost model and the package build. They don't record how many retainers she signed or what they're worth, so this page doesn't give a figure.

What would one retainer client change for you?

One retainer client changes what next month looks like before it arrives. If you added one this quarter, just one, what would it change about how next month feels?

The method behind this story. [How to move from one-off video projects to recurring revenue](#): the retainer offer skeleton, the email to an existing client, the answer to "we don't need video every month" and a worked retainer price, all copy and paste.

Related tools and guides. [How to price a video project](#), [Pricing Calculator](#), [Account expansion](#), [One-client dependency](#), [Know your numbers](#).



The field guides show you how the system works. The Boardroom is where I look at your business with you, give you perspective and judgement on what to do next, and hold you to it every week.

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